dispatches was clear: 'If Ershad's confrontational attitude persists, he needs to go.'

Return of the Shadow Operators

Within days of arriving in Dhaka in the first week of November 1988, the R&AW station head codenamed Krishna Patwardhan, held a meeting with junior agents. The first thing Patwardhan asked was whether agents operating under the overwhelming surveillance mounted by the Bangladesh dictatorship had been successful in maintaining their covers. The answer was no. The local staff employed at the mission were informers for Ershad and not a single Indian spy in Dhaka had been able to keep the iron mask intact.

Ershad had been under tremendous pressure from political movements of all shades to hold fresh elections. However, he dissolved parliament in December 1987 and declared an emergency before his government announced the dates for a fresh mandate. The dictator declared that the elections would be held in February 1988 and then, postponed them to March. The BNP, Awami League and Jamaat-e-Islami boycotted the polls, allowing Ershad's political front, the Jatiyo Party, to capture two hundred and fifty-one seats out of three hundred in parliament. The Bangladesh army exercised absolute power and Indian officials operating in Dhaka were put under intense surveillance.

Patwardhan discovered other vulnerabilities of operations in Dhaka and decided to set up a standard procedure to facilitate targeting Ershad's opponents in. But he was more worried about the deep divisions between the political parties of Bangladesh. The primary concern was the much-publicised rift between the BNP's Begum Khaleda Zia and the Awami League's Sheikh